Investigations revealed the syndicate had booked hotel rooms for over a 100 candidates in Digha, West Bengal, for similar coaching sessions. None of them, however, turned up after the buses to Vizianagaram were intercepted. The racket appeared to have contacted nearly 500 aspirants in all, promising them leaked question papers in exchange for bribes ranging from Rs 15-25 lakh. Members allegedly included brokers, transporters and habitual offenders active in multiple states.

Among those identified as key players is Pradeep Sethi from Khallikote, earlier detained for his role in an Odisha Teacher Eligibility Test (OTET) malpractice case. The discovery that many of the arrested aspirants had links to the Banik Coaching Centre in Bhubaneswar led to a raid, but Banik's MD Subrat Chhatoi denied any wrongdoing and assured full cooperation to the police. The Crime Branch says several key conspirators are still on the run. So far, 123 people have been arrested.

OUTRAGE OUT THERE

The scandal has caused public outrage, with protests erupting across the state. After hundreds of aspirants took to the streets demanding justice, the OPRB has promised the exam—indefinitely postponed for now—would be conducted transparently after the probe. But public trust stands shattered. Last year, similar protests had erupted when the Odisha Subordinate Staff Selection Committee (OSSSC) outsourced recruitment for Revenue Inspectors and other posts to private agencies.

Opposition parties have expectedly raised their pitch. The Biju Janata Dal alleged influential figures were involved, accused the BJP-led government of shielding the guilty and demanded a CBI probe. The Congress called for a court-monitored probe. CM Mohan Charan Majhi has said the probe would be handed over to the CBI, citing the scam's inter-state nature. As its special skills come into play, what's at stake are uncomfortable questions related to transparency and accountability. ■

▶ KERALA

WAYANAD SURVIVORS FACE APATHY

Having lost their all in the 2024 landslides, the needle moves slowly as the Centre and state play politics over relief

By **Jeemon Jacob**



BADUSHA P. T.

IT WAS ON JULY 30, 2024, IN THE pitch dark before dawn, that hell and high water came hurtling down on a serene corner of Wayanad. Two villages, Mundakkai and Chooralmala, were wiped off the map. Some 298 lives were stubbed out, 35 others could not be traced. Over a year later, Kerala is battling to stave off a disaster of another kind. At its centre is an empty space: nothing has yet filled the blanks nature left on those high ranges. State succour has been a slow-moving mirage, till now. Reason: the animus between Kerala and New Delhi.

The irony is that politics, often the nemesis of the rational and humane path, may yet offer some redemption. Kerala is due for an assembly election by May 2026, and the unfinished Wayanad rehabilitation would constitute a big blot on the Pinarayi Vijayan government if the situation is not amended soon. The incentive is high, therefore, to put the spurs on a 'Wayanad Model Village' project currently under construction. It was in February this year, after six months of frustrating negotiations with the Centre, that the LDF government announced that it would finance the rehabilitation substantially on its own, earmarking Rs 750 crore for it.

MODEL TO REALITY

What that's feeding presently is a brand-new colony for survivors at Elstone Estate: 410 2BHK housing units of 1,000 square feet each on seven-cent plots. The district administration is working overtime to complete the project by December 31. The initial plan was for two model townships—at Nedumbala Estate and Elstone. The state's cussedly politicking